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Michael Weiss

Michael Weiss has made a significant contribution to jazz as a pianist, composer, and educator. In addition to leading his own ensembles, Michael has played with numerous jazz luminaries, including Johnny Griffin, Art Farmer, and Charles McPherson.

Michael was interviewed via Zoom on December 22, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe, I'm very happy to have Michael Weiss here today, composer, pianist, and educator. And I'm going to backtrack to about 15 seconds ago and you said Art Farmer used to call you "Veiss" because of his time across the pond. And that one statement I'm like jealous. Because Art Farmer never had, you know, I was never with him and have the opportunity where he could mispronounce my name. So congratulations on that.

MW: You're very welcome. Thank you.

MR: This is a broad question. You moved to New York in the 80s, is that correct?

MW: Well the very end of 1981. By January of 1982 I had an apartment and I was in. So I'm about reaching my fortieth anniversary as a New Yorker.

MR: If we can ignore the Covid time for a moment, can you compare the way you made a living back then, in the 80s, and what you're doing now? And does it reflect New York as a jazz scene?

MW: There were a lot more gigs, to put it simply. There were a lot more gigs to be had for piano players in New York in the 80s and the 90s, because I guess — well there were a lot of clubs but there were also restaurants that had jazz and had very good jazz pianists and had good pianos. And I don't know, there seemed to be a lot more to do, overall.

MR: And why the change?

MW: Well just fewer clubs, fewer restaurants having jazz. I don't know the reason.

MR: Is jazz a hard sell these days more than it used to be? It's never — it's been a long time since it was sort of the popular music of the day, but I wonder as time goes by if people's attention span and their listening habits make it harder to sort of sell jazz.

MW: I think it's live music of all kinds have been affected across the board, from the top down. From the most popular pop stars, you know, down to the semi-professional, or semi-amateur solo folk guitarist. I think it's — live music has been affected across the board. And I don't know if it just has to do with advances in technology, the internet, but I mean I think of in the 80s even Madison Square Garden, Giants Stadium, pop stars would fill — you know Billy Joel to Bruce Springsteen, Madonna, Prince, Michael Jackson,

whoever, would fill 50,000 seat stadiums regularly. And I don't think that exists for them anymore either.

MR: Okay. When you were a kid growing up, I read that you started with classical piano lessons but that you took to starting to pick out popular tunes. And when they said you "picked them out" what was that process like for you? And did you have a sort of an aha moment where you can remember where you said oh this is how music works or I'm able to do this, this is how songs are put together?

MW: Well I think from the time I started piano lessons around the age of six I think I probably realized that I had perfect pitch and that I could hear music and go to the piano and know what the notes were. My earliest musical memories are The Beatles and all mid-60s pop music. And I remember going to the piano and trying to figure some of those songs out by ear. And in my early teens I started to have little garage rock bands — I got an organ, a Farfisa organ and I played that. My aha moments came later.

MR: Okay, before we get to those, which I definitely want to, I'm wondering at what point when you were playing you know the Farfisa did you realize that these chords that you were playing had actual names and the symbols for them, and that often times one led to another.

MW: I really have no recollection of when I became aware of chord symbols. I'm sure I understood major and minor and dominant seventh chords because I was recognizing and addressing that in the classical music I was playing and the pop music I was playing, but I had an innate understanding of those things. But I really don't remember the first time that I saw or wrote down chord symbols. Probably — maybe not until I was aware of jazz.

MR: And was one of your aha moments becoming aware of jazz and how did that occur?

MW: That was the first one. When I was 15 my piano teacher suggested that I attend the Interlochen Music Camp in Michigan. This was 1973. And up to that point I didn't know a thing about jazz. I might have, I could have heard of the name Louis Armstrong but I don't remember. Nothing. Zero. And what was great about that music camp, I remember getting some paperwork in the mail and a selection of courses, just like registering for college. At 11 a.m. you can take this, you can take that, you can take that, and here's something called "jazz improvisation." I don't know what that is, let's see what that is. But early in the term of the camp the faculty jazz quintet performed a concert, and that was really my first exposure to jazz and I remember they played, it was a relatively new release on CTI, they played "Straight Life" of Freddie Hubbard. And it just blew me away. And immediately, without hesitation, that's — however I formulated the thought in my mind I would translate that now as this is your life mission right here, right now. So intellectually, spiritually, every kind of way my mind was ready for this more advanced

music. And I grabbed onto it instantly and, to give you the degree of that, within six weeks or so I had written a big band arrangement. And I thank, will forever be grateful to Dave Sporny, who ran the jazz program there at that time, and laid out the harmonic theory and the ins and outs of everything about jazz pedagogy. And I soaked it up like a sponge. Incidentally I had a chance to hear Duke Ellington and his orchestra who came through, as well as the Stan Kenton band, which had a very young Interlochen alumnus Peter Erskine at the drums. When I started high school that fall in Dallas, Texas, there was like a career development type of early edition of a magnet high school. So under that roof I had four hours of music a day every day, every school day, that included an hour of big band rehearsal. So anything I wanted to write I could get played, you know, the next morning. All I had to do was stay up all night to copy the parts, which I did quite a bit, to the detriment of my first period English class. But that was it, I was on my way.

MR: Well you had that in common with Duke Ellington. There's nothing like that instant gratification or information that you gain from that. How did you learn about voicings and ranges and what to do and what not to do? Just from trial and error?

MW: Well I got that very practical early training from Dave Sporny, you know it was the first time I saw how a trombone worked, what a trumpet did, the range, the transpositions, all the different ways to harmonize a melody, four part, five part harmony, double the lead, passing diminished chords, all this type of stuff he laid out so clearly. Fortunately at that time, as you might recall, Kendor Music Publishing was publishing a lot of Thad Jones's music, which was great. It was like the greatest thing that could have happened to jazz education at the time was for big bands to play Thad Jones's music. And so that was one of my first big influences. And just, yeah trial and error, just trying to apply, you know I didn't really study his scores per se but what I was hearing in the band and my understanding of theoretical ideas about moving harmony and so forth, I was trying a lot of things out, yeah.

MR: Yeah. We just played "Groove Merchant" here about ten days ago, from Thad's book.

MW: Sure. Well everything kind of came full circle because once I was in New York I began subbing on the Vanguard Jazz Orchestra, first with Mel and then after Mel. And then, even though I wasn't an official member of the band I probably played more gigs as the pianist of the band than any other pianist in the history of the — I think I played over 700 gigs with the band, or 600, something crazy. But all to say that as a professional musician I was able to sit inside the band night after night and Thad's genius just never becomes tiresome. It's wonderful. And I became good friends with Roland Hanna and interacted professionally with a number of other alumni of the band.

MR: I was going to save this question for later but you're talking about early on learning how to voice horns. I wonder if that experience translated to the way you comp at the piano? That your hands may be recreating or have in mind how you voice those horns?

MW: Absolutely. You know what an arranger does in the big band is orchestrated accompaniment, and at the piano is improvised accompaniment. But they should be just as good. They should both be as good as possible. And what I found is that, not to get too technical here, but a good voicing, a good spacing of chord tones and intervals over whatever given range you're working with, a good voicing is good on the piano, just as good as it is with horns. And for example what Thad might write for eight brass, four trombones and four trumpets, would sound great on the piano. So yeah, there's I think all the types of considerations — range, where you put certain chord tones, how you voice things — I apply equally to the piano as I do to horns.

MR: Before the days of Finale and those programs where you can hear your work back if you choose, this is not a question just an observation, because I've done quite a bit of it myself and there was nothing like that feeling of spending all this time writing a chart, copying the parts, and that first time it gets played back to you, which can be a joy or perhaps not.

MW: Well it's the truth, right? It's right there. Hopefully you have the sensitivity and the understanding to know if something works well or not as well as you thought. You know it's how you process that information is just as important as experiencing it.

MR: Yeah and if you haven't done it well you have to be careful not to blame the players. Like that's not supposed to sound that way what are you doing.

MW: Well sometimes that is an issue. You know? Like I'm very detail oriented. I'm very specific the way I perceive of a melody, the way I conceive of a melody for example, or the phrasing of any phrase, the articulation of a phrase. The way I would play it on the piano, the way I conceive it is how I want it. And when you notate something for another musician, a horn player for example, if you're going to put articulation markings they must be observed. You don't want them to be ignored. But there are so many subtleties, it really can't be notated, written down, that well. And learning something by ear is obviously the best and the purest way to understand a composer's intent. And there's no better example than Monk. When you listen to the way Charlie Rouse for example, plays Monk's melodies with him, he plays them — well first of all Monk plays the melody with the saxophonist most of the time. So the saxophonist has to listen to how Monk is phrasing his melodies, which notes are short, which notes are long, which notes get the accent, which notes are legato, which notes are not legato. But I don't know for a fact but I would be sure that I would guess that Rouse learned Monk's tunes from Monk by ear. I know Johnny Griffin told me that he never saw any music of Monk's, that he actually had

to learn the songs for the first time on the bandstand at the Five Spot. And Monk would just play the melody over and over again until he got it. But once he got it it was as pure as Monk's intent could be because there is no other type of interpretation, here it is. Copy that.

MR: I got a little flash — last night I was listening to one of your performances that's on YouTube and Walt Weiskopf was playing and I think it was "Soul Journey." And he played the melody, especially in the beginning, it was so pure, like devoid of excess vibrato, every note was hit right on the head. And as a saxophone player I was thinking to myself I wonder if you wanted that kind of purity from him, and did he know it or did you instruct him, or maybe it just happened?

MW: I think he read the music verbatim and there was nothing I needed to say. There weren't any adjustments needed. So it was what I wanted. It's a very orchestrated melody. It's not the kind of melody that you interpret like a standard that you change a rhythm or change a note because that's what you feel on that particular day. It's pretty cut and dry.

MR: I'm not who makes too much out of titles and their relationship to the actual music but it seemed an effective way to start that piece because it left a lot of room for where to go with it.

MW: Okay.

MR: Where do your titles come from?

MW: Well they come last. You know sometimes I joke about you know the fan that comes up to you after the set and says, "Boy it must be so great to make music. When you're feeling sad, do you want to write a sad song?" It's like, "No, when I'm sad I want to watch — veg out in front of the television and crack open a beer" or, you know, the mood that you're in is not what you're in when you compose. You know? When you compose you're in a certain frame of mind and you draw on your experience of various emotions and things that you want to communicate. You don't necessarily have to be in that frame of mind when you are composing, obviously. So to answer the question, the last thing I think about usually is the title. It's purely a musical experience or expression. It's after that is complete then you can go back and say okay well what does this, what's the mood of this piece? What does it evoke? What does it make you think of when you listen to it? And that's when you start to think about a title. That's when I start to think about a title.

MR: I love this topic, because I've always been fascinated with many times you see writers who define improvising and jazz and improvisers are playing what they feel. They're expressing themselves. And I may be misreading their intentions but I always get the impression that they think jazz musicians are expressing their innermost feelings whenever they're improvising. And I wonder how you feel about that? What is the role of

emotion when you're — if you're playing a bop tune at 180 beats per minute how much emotion can your improvising express?

MW: Well in the language there's always an emotional component. There should be an emotional component. Just like — there's so many great analogies to human speech, to verbal communication, sentence structure, storytelling. And a good storyteller will emphasize a certain word in a sentence, or will pause between phrases or clauses for a certain effect, for a certain intent, will accent a certain syllable to get their point across in a more communicative, more direct, more emotional type of way. So I think all that applies to music. There are so many different parameters, you know, it's not only rhythm, it's not only melody, it's not only one dynamic, it's not only short notes, it's not only long notes. Every one of these components become part of your story. Sometimes your idea is rhythmically based. Sometimes it's melodically based. Sometimes you play a very short declamatory phrase and then you follow that with a longer more melodious phrase. Yeah, I think there must be some type of emotional content in what you play. If it's entirely an intellectual exercise then, you know, everyone can do what they want. Everyone has their own idea of what's of good taste. And you know, this music is here for everybody to do whatever they want with it. So what one person says is good or bad or should be or should not be, who am I to tell someone what to do or what's good or what's bad for them?

MR: Right. Well said. When you moved to New York in the early 80s, were you a goal-type person? Had you laid out a plan for what you hoped would happen?

MW: No. I'm a little too disorganized for that. I mean to have this sort of, I'm pretty much a more spontaneous type of person, however, I did know that I wanted to play, I got the most gratification from playing with great players, players that I admired, players that I looked up to. I aspired to play with the players that I used to listen to on records that were in New York. I got great satisfaction out of being able to be on the bandstand and to be making music with my idols. And that was the type of career path that I guess I wanted to have. I wanted to come up through the ranks so to speak, because that was what I saw through all my recordings, sidemen who gained more and more appearances on recordings and became leaders in their own right, who established a track record, credentials — professional credentials — and I thought that's the way I wanted my career to progress.

MR: I see a collection of LPs behind you. And I know I used to spend many hours reading liner notes and almost like keeping track of how many LPs does Clark Terry show up on? And that kind of thing. And I wondered if you did that and did you envision some day seeing your name?

MW: No. I didn't really think like that. I'm not — I have a lot of records here but I'm not really a real record collector. I'm not a completist, you know. I have a lot of Jackie McLean records but I don't have them all. I have a lot of records of particular artists but there are some that I don't have that maybe a lot of people have in their collections, I just didn't get around to it. I never really — I never really thought of like, okay one day I'm going to have a hit record, I'm going to do everything I can to be a Blue Note recording artist. I was just happy playing with great players and being able to tour with them. That was a sort of a mark of arrival, a confirmation that I'm doing what I set out to do.

MR: You've played with a long list of really accomplished saxophonists, in particular. And I wondered if we started with Johnny Griffin, did he tell you what he wanted if he wasn't getting it? Or did he pretty much let you do your thing?

MW: In all those years he never gave any specific instruction. He never said do more of this, do less of that. So I have to assume that he was happy with how I was playing and how the rhythm section was playing. He wasn't real analytical in that kind of way. I mean the way he played you had to, you understood what's the best type of accompaniment for him. It's different from other soloists you know. He's very exuberant and effusive and bubbling. He's like a bottle of champagne that has a lot of bubbles. So he's bubbling all over the place, so you have to let that happen you know? There's a yin and yang of soloists and accompanists. There's only so much room in the bar for notes so the busier somebody plays, a soloist plays, the less busy the accompanist plays. And the more sparse a soloist plays the busier an accompanist can play. You know. Miles Davis's rhythm sections let's say with Wynton Kelly and let's say with Herbie Hancock could never have done what they did if Miles didn't give them the space to do it. You know it's a two way street there. So getting back to Grif, you know he was, he had his certain predictabilities and he had a lot of unpredictabilities and you had to manage that and not get in the way and let things happen. Find your spots. Pick your spots.

MR: Did you have much music on the piano when you played with him?

MW: No.

MR: Lead sheets? Chord charts?

MW: No. We pretty much learned the repertoire very fast. You know I can't recall any gig [with Griffin] where I had music on the piano as a matter of fact, except maybe a record date or something, but not on the gig.

MR: Is that something you try to pass on to jazz majors in college? The fact that those years that you played at that level that you were playing from intuition and memory?

MW: I mean yes of course. That's the biggest problem — probably one of the most fundamental problems with jazz education is an emphasis on reading music and not using your ear and not pulling the music away. But so much of this has to do with the

professional experience. You know there's so fewer opportunities for younger players to work, to play, to perform on a regular basis, to apprentice with established players, to have to kind of sink or swim in that, on the bandstand so to speak. Those skills are just gone away. You know? If there were a lot more performing opportunities with a — that were still using the *Great American Songbook* you know, young sidemen would just have to buckle down and be able to learn and hear songs that they didn't know on the bandstand. I've experienced that throughout my career. Every time I get on the bandstand with George Coleman I'm going to learn a new song. Lou Donaldson. You know like Lou would never announce a song before he plays it. He never counted a song off before he started to play it. He never tapped his foot into a song, he just started playing the melody of the song he wanted to play in tempo and you were expected to know it. One time he — we were playing a gig in Connecticut and he started to play [scats] and Jamil Nasser is playing and the drummer is playing. And I'm like, I'm frozen. I don't know what that is. And he turned around and he looked at me, he says, "Ha you don't know that man? A-ha-ha-ha." And I learned it, by a chorus I had it. It was a song called "You." Sonny Rollins recorded it. But that's how you learn.

MR: Does it help because you had perfect pitch that you can listen to the bass player and that's vital what the bass player is playing, especially if you don't know a tune.

MW: Well you better hope the bass player knows it. What do you do if he doesn't know it either? You're making assumptions there.

MR: Really. The bass player is sneaking over to look at your left hand and you're going, "Sorry."

MW: Yeah. So you have to get your clues from wherever you can find them. Obviously the more songs you know the more ways you know a harmonic progression might likely go, or what chords a melody is implying by the tonality that the melody is in at the moment.

MR: You had a statement from *Jazz Times* and you said the 60s and 70s age group was the last of the truth. And I'm assuming you're talking about some of the people like Johnny Griffin you've played with, and I'm wondering what you meant by the last of the truth?

MW: Well it was probably a long time ago.

MR: It was quite a while back and you were also commenting on the public's exposure to mediocre talent. I think it might have been the same article.

MW: Well a lot of things have changed since then. My outlook, the way I think about things have probably changed since then. But yeah. First I think of the players who established themselves in various heydays of the development of this music as the truth because it's unfiltered, it's from the horse's mouth so to speak, and successive younger generations, you know, are reinterpreting and it's just another filtration system that's going on. And sometimes — sometimes yes, sometimes not — and again everything comes down to

one's own idea of good taste but a certain authenticity, a certain way of delivering this language is represented by those players. And you know as they pass on what people now think of what jazz is is left to later generations of how people play these days. And I think there's so much, there's so many components to the language of jazz that it developed over the years, over almost a hundred years now. They go through a lot of different transformations and I think that's what I was trying to express when I said that.

MR: The stylistic changes in that hundred years are quite amazing and I'm wondering if it becomes harder and harder to be innovative and still create music that is listenable and appealing?

MW: You know it's all up to the music maker, what choices they make. You know I mean we were talking about what you were asking me about before — the last of the truth — I think what came to mind is like the way Frank Wess plays a phrase on his horn. He's expressing his life experience. My experience and someone in their 30s or in their 20s can't possibly have that experience to be able to express that way on their horn, what he heard, what he grew up with, what's in his DNA. That's what I'm talking about. And you know to be able to play with somebody like that first-hand and experience that is priceless.

MR: Yeah I was wondering if you had words for — I have this little scenario in my head, you're playing a gig with Frank Wess in a club in New York and it went well. And on the way home what are you feeling inside after that experience?

MW: I'm — well look I'm relatively critical of my own playing and I'm probably less concerned with how other people performed on a given night you know. Was I in a good zone? Was everything working well? Was my — all my antennas working well? I don't know. I'm not quite so analytical that I make a whole study of it. Basically the gig is over, on to the next.

MR: I see. I guess what I was wondering about —

MW: I'm not sure what you are getting at.

MR: Well I over the years have been lucky through this project I do to find myself briefly on a bandstand with people like Joe Wilder and of that generation. And I just remember almost like I need to pinch myself. Because here I am and there he is and I was hoping to do a good job but I think I just was filled with gratitude that that could happen, that this was happening.

MW: Yeah. I mean look there's — just listening – I worked a fair amount with Joe Wilder and just listening to him play is so wonderful, as is with so many of these musicians we're talking about. There's great joy and satisfaction of just being on the bandstand regardless of what you do, just listening to what comes out of their horn. And you've got a job to do and you do it as well as you can. And this experience of this collaborative art form

teaches you how to be in the moment and in the present. And to me the whole game that ties everything together is the cooperation or the successful cooperation of your conscious and subconscious. You know what I mean by that?

MR: I'd be happy to have you expand on that.

MW: You know when you're in the musical moment, when you're in the act of a creative improvised endeavor, you have to have all your faculties working at top, at a top level. But when you're improvising, when you're soloing for example, you have to get out of the way of your creativity and that means letting it — there are all types of phrases. We say let it happen, get out of the way, having a flow, a creative flow. All that is letting your, you know all your storehouse of ideas that you improvise, that come out, the story you tell spontaneously originates from your subconscious. Your subconscious is all the things you know. And you can't be able to say everything that you know all at once, because not everything comes to you all at once, so where is it? It's in your storehouse, your history of experience I think is sitting in your subconscious. That's like a vessel where all these ideas and experiences reside and when you're improvising you're trying to get these ideas to bubble up to the surface, to come out and in a beautiful, uninterrupted flow. And in the conscious mind there are a number of impediments that impede that creative flow. It can be distractions. It can be the piano is out of tune. It could be the person is talking too loud next to you, the drummer is too loud, there is a note sticking on the piano, the light is too bright, you have a stomach ache. Any number of distractions. Sometimes when you're playing you feel like you don't have any ideas at all and you're just sitting there going through the motions. The fingers are leading you and you're hoping that the fingers will lead you to someplace that spark an idea that you can actually, actively, that you can activate. A little catalyst. But at the moment there's no catalyst. You are uninspired. What do you do to inspire yourself? To jumpstart your creative flow? So to me this is like the battle that goes on every time, every single time I'm on the bandstand. What's going to come out? How inspired will I be? How freely will my ideas flow? Because there's so much — you know what comes out at any given moment like maybe a thousandth of what you could do. A hundredth. You know how would you rate a given gig or a given song or a given solo in terms of your potential? What's a good night? What's a good solo? Well I think I reached maybe 15 percent of my potential, that was really good. Or man I think I got up to 25, maybe 30 percent of my potential, things are really — do you know what I'm trying to say here? So to me it's that battle between, it's like trying to get that subconscious mind to just release its storehouse of what you know, what you can do of given various catalysts. Sometimes there are certain tricks I'll do sometimes to try to push myself into having to force a different type of creative situation. Like sometimes I'll, rather than continuing where I've gone a

million times before I'll look at another range of the piano and I'll say I'm going to make myself start my phrase up here, not because I hear it but just to make myself do it, and then, what does that make me do? Sometimes you have to trick yourself to, you know accidents are how things get going. You have to create an accident. You have to almost, maybe you have to deliberately hit a note that you don't, you wouldn't hear necessarily, you wouldn't normally go there but that opens up a whole process of, you know, creative possibilities. How do I make, if you think this is a quote unquote wrong note or unintended note, how do you make it right? How do you justify it musically?

MR: Is there any preparation that you do before the gig that may assist you in getting to that point where you want to be before you play?

MW: There probably is you know. I haven't been very methodical about that but I'm sure, you know for example people who meditate regularly have a certain discipline, develop a discipline to put them in a certain frame of mind before they do what they have to do. I could probably count on one hand the times when I reached like what seemed like an optimal state of mind when improvising was almost an out of body experience. I think playing every night, I mean it's very hard to reach those states of mind when you're playing a gig, three gigs a month or once a week or something like that. It's no accident that John Coltrane developed as he did. Well first of all he was a practice-a-holic even when the gig was over he had the horn out. But playing, there's no experience like playing night after night, five, six nights a week, maybe even playing the same repertoire with the same band on tour, to get you in that place. I was talking about this recently with Charles McPherson just last week, talking about, you know, mind frame for having a, you know, the most desired frame of mind you're trying to have when you're trying to improvise. And he said that he saw an interview with Bird where he was, Bird was asked, "So what are you thinking about when you're playing?" And Bird said, "I look down at my fingers and I can't believe that it's me." Dig it? So that's what I'm talking about, that out-of-mind — I mean it's happened a few times where I was playing and I could actually like leave my body and stand over my shoulder and watch what I was doing kind of thing. Sometimes I'll try and get in that frame of mind while I'm playing — I'll look somewhere else. I'll look at the wall. I'll look across the room. Just as a way to free up my mind, to just be in the zone so to speak.

MR: Do you recall if those rare moments where all that came together were in a trio context or solo piano context? My reason for asking that is I'm wondering, the people that you play with over the years, have you made note of bassists and drummers who are the best helpers for you to enter that comfort zone?

MW: Not particularly. I mean obviously if a drummer is bombastic or a bass player is doing something, if either of them are doing something that's distracting in some kind of way,

that's going to be a hindrance. But nothing really more specific than that. I think what I was talking about really happens like during a solo, improvising a solo, where it's almost like yeah, out-of-body experience where you're just watching it happen and you're not standing in the way at all. You know everything is — you're completely aware of what the chord is of what the tempo is, of all that stuff, but you're not thinking about it at all. I think Bird was also quoted, there was some interview like about what he practices or whatever, like learn it and then forget it. Not forget it that you can't do it anymore but forget it that it becomes a subconscious. You've mastered it and you don't have to think about it while you do it, you just do it effortlessly.

MR: It becomes deposited in that part of your subconscious that you were talking about. It can come back for you.

MW: Yeah. I mean there are so many analogies like with sports. People who do things, let's say collaborative type of engagements where you're operating on an enormous level of craft and expertise's but the realization of that business is spontaneous and purely instinctual. You know like when an offensive guard or right tackle is lined up seconds before the play starts, he knows what the play is, he knows what his role is, but what happens within a half a second after the snap is a purely spontaneous event. And that particular player as well as all the players are operating entirely on instinct. So I think there's a lot of correlation with the improvising jazz musician.

MR: Thanks. That's some very valuable insight into that mysterious and rather magical process that happens in jazz. Did you have life lessons? You talked about going on the road and how important that was with mostly people who were older than you. In your observations of them, what kind of things did you learn?

MW: One important lesson was how they could easily let the unpredictabilities or when things like being on the road, when things go wrong, when things don't go according to plan, how easily they could let those things roll off their back. How it didn't bother them half as much as it was bothering me. And that was an important lesson to learn. Why are we taking a 7 a.m. flight? The gig is not until 9 o'clock at night and the flight is only an hour and a half long. Why are we having to get up to take this flight? There is eight flights that day. And I'm bitching and I'm mad and blah-blah-blah. And I look at the bandleaders, they just roll with it. So road experiences like that. Like okay, shut up. Deal with it. You know if it doesn't bother them it shouldn't bother you. Just yeah, professional decorum, how the bandleader presented their music to the audience, every leader has their own way of communicating with the audience, of presenting their repertoire, of engaging with the audience. All different — all these types of things you know, how they conducted themselves as bandleaders, as businessmen, as entertainers, all that kind of stuff.

MR: Excellent. I wanted to run a couple of names by you. We already talked about Joe Wilder. And maybe you have something you can offer on Jon Hendricks?

MW: Well Jon had good taste in a lot of things. He liked to live well. He was a complete natural and he's probably one of the very very few vocalists who could improvise a jazz solo on par with any horn player. He really knew the language. He really got it. And when I worked with him he had four singers, it was like an expanded Lambert, Hendricks & Ross type of repertoire, but every set included at least two or three songs just quartet with Jon and the rhythm section. And that was very very satisfying and enjoyable because it was just like playing a quartet with a tenor saxophonist.

MR: Is vocal accompaniment the challenging — a different sort of playing for you?

MW: I don't do it that much. Actually I don't have a whole lot of experience like some pianists, working with vocalists. But I'd like to think the same criteria are in play you know, with a vocalist singing a ballad or a tenor saxophonist singing a ballad through their horn.

MR: How about Marian McPartland?

MW: Well I only had one personal experience with her and that was being on her show.

MR: Yes, I wondered how that felt for you?

MW: It was a little challenging because there was no rehearsal, no talk through. It was just sit down and the tape is rolling. You know. I think we played maybe two songs together. She played a couple, I played a few, we talked a little bit, and before you knew it it was over. She got the good piano. I remember there were two pianos and it was her piano and the piano I played on had a pretty stiff action. It was like damn.

MR: Well she was the host.

MW: She was the host.

MR: This has been a wonderful conversation and I want to wrap up with something I heard last night of you playing at Small's, a quartet with Steve Wilson. And I think you were playing a song called "Atlantis." And I heard, I think, this little motif and I'll try to hum it [scats]. And it came up every once in a while and it struck me like this is your way — forgive me if I'm making too much out of this, but it sounded like you were doing this with the idea of sort of marking a part in this performance and keeping the audience with you. That's the way it struck me.

MW: Well it's just the pick-up bar of the melody. It's the opening line of the song. It's not the — it's just the pick-up line into the melody, it's not the melody per se, it's just the opening into the melody. But let's see, I think the way the form of the piece goes there was a little vamp section, there was the song form which was an open number of choruses for each soloist. And when the soloist plays his last chorus he cues into a little

vamp section that's four times. And at the end of that we used that pick-up of the melody to bring in the next soloist.

MR: That's what I heard.

MW: It was used as sort of a button, the end, they lived happily ever after, on to the next. Yeah. It's a little marker. A melodic marker. Yeah. Using and re-using your material, repetition or sequencing is the hallmark of a good song. And it can be referred to as a hook, but any — I talk about this, I recently did an online composition and arranging master class called "Getting More Out of Your Tunes" where almost any good song has some repetition in it, has some sequencing. You can't just have a continuous run-on sentence of new material without ever repeating anything because I think the listener will turn off. But if you just repeat something, you can even change it when you repeat it, a variation of some sort, but any type of sequence, a sequence, repetition, whatever you call it, when a listener hears something a second time it's like then they get it so that now they're ready to hear new information. But if you're only giving out new information all the time then you can't process it. I went to the store, I looked at computers, I looked at monitors, then I went and had a coffee. So you know what I'm saying? It's like you're ready for something new. And I think a good solo tells a story in a similar kind of way. You can't just have a whole series of non sequiturs. There's a great interview with Pat Metheny I saw recently where he talked about how so many young improvisers today, their solos are just made up of non sequiturs. And it's so true.

MR: Yeah, that's a good observation. Well this has really been a fascinating conversation and I congratulate you on your career so far. And I hope that you will be thought of as one of those people like when you apprenticed with Johnny Griffin that people will be doing that with you.

MW: I hope so.

MR: Yeah.

MW: You know all we need right now is just work. Like I talked about before, we need, the jazz musician needs to play. You just can't develop as an artist unless you're able to do it all the time.

MR: All right.

MW: Another sports analogy, you know like a baseball season is 162 games. That's like six games a week for six months. So, and even with that, a great batting average is like three out of ten times you get a hit. Imagine if you just play one game a week, what's your average going to be then?

MR: Well I wish you the best average possible in these times. Thanks a lot, Michael.

MW: It was great to be with you, Monk, thanks for having me.